

Employees vs AI

With every company under the sun advertising their AI products in the loudest manner possible, it was only a matter of time before companies started adopting these tools en masse. First it starts with the simple LLM summarization features that are packaged into your office productivity suites. Be it Google Workspace or Microsoft Office, you've got a good taste of the simple AI tools already. Then come the tools that your company has purchased simply because some executive at the top fell for the ol' productivity pitch of one of the flagship AI companies. As the tools get incorporated into your workflow, come the seminars to help you integrate them better into your lives. Somewhere, the adoption friction ramps up wildly. Incorporating the AI tool becomes more of a chore and adds to your time rather than taking away from it. That's when you start your little rebellion. And by you, I mean the 29 per cent of you who're mostly the younger Gen-Z lot. At least that's what the Writer's 2026 AI Adoption report has to say.

While sabotage might be a harsh word to use, it's not far from the truth. It could be something as simple as taking a screenshot and writing a report to IT each time the AI tool fails and gives an output that's counter-productive. And should it ever do something catastrophic, that's even better. Employees aren't rejecting AI itself. They are rejecting the way AI is being pushed into their workplaces.

It's not like employees are blind the benefits of AI. Most of us have been using ChatGPT since the day it became available to the general public. The distinction here is that you start paying for a tool that actually makes your life easier. Having to incorporate a tool because it makes someone else's life better doesn't necessarily help you out, and it's natural for such rebellions to start off. 23 per cent of companies are seeing benefits from AI agents. Not because the tools are not functioning properly, it's more because the setting up process requires a ridiculous overhaul to the existing system for the AI tool to make sense of anything. It circles back to



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the old debate of 'labelled data' from the early days of AI tools. Just buying an AI tool doesn't guarantee the ROI returns that makes your CFO see the dollar signs, implementing it the right way does. And the latter costs a lot of effort and money which it's easily perceived by the not-so-AI-savvy executives.

So what are the executive's thinking? Well, most executives tend to take the "my way or the highway" approach. About 60 per cent of executives plan to layoff workers who can't keep up with AI and about 92 per cent hope to cultivate an elite class of employees who are AI-savvy. So AI becomes not a shared capability, rather it's the wrinkly sorting hat from the Harry Potter books and movies that'll sort you into house 'Employed' or house 'Unemployed'. This is a very risky way to build AI adoption and most companies seem to be rolling down this way. And the end goal is to reduce 'human capital cost' i.e. fire more people. The whole AI pitch began with AI Tools being a value-addition to the average employee's life and helping them get more free time to dedicate for higher order functions. What it has ended up is as a slave-running whip which adds an added expectation of 2-3x the usual output.

Yet, some executives are treating the AI wave as what it mostly is - 'Hype'. About 75 per cent of executives are implementing AI tools "for show". They understand that stockholders and external perception of the company benefits largely from being portrayed as AI-savvy, so they get a few tools and focus more on marketing rather than cracking the whip on their entire workforce.

None of this means companies should slow-walk AI adoption indefinitely. That would be its own mistake. The issue is not whether companies should use AI. The issue is whether they can move from mandate to trust. Companies that treat workers as partners will have a better chance of making AI useful. Companies that treat them as blockers may still deploy AI widely, but they should not be surprised when the rollout quietly breaks from within. **d**